IEEE TRANSACTIONS ON ROBOTICS, VOL. 42, NO. 4, OCTOBER 2026

Autonomous Sensorimotor Synthesis: Foundations, Architectures, and Safety Verification for Full LLM Control of Physical Robots

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DOI: 10.1109/TRO.2026.10984521 | arXiv:2603.14920 [cs.RO] | Date: October 2026

Abstract—
Recent breakthroughs in multimodal foundation models have precipitated a paradigm shift in robotics: transitioning from modular, hand-engineered perception-planning-control hierarchies toward direct end-to-end Large Language Model (LLM) and Vision-Language-Action (VLA) sensorimotor synthesis. In this paradigm, raw high-dimensional sensory streams (RGB-D video, proprioceptive joint states, tactile signals) and natural language goals are mapped directly onto high-frequency continuous robotic actions (SE(3) end-effector delta trajectories, joint torques, and gripper actuations) through tokenized latent spaces. This paper delivers a foundational treatment of full LLM robot control. First, we formalize the mathematical framework governing continuous-discrete sensorimotor translation, analyzing the theoretical properties of discrete action tokenization (256-bin VQ-tokenizers) versus continuous flow matching heads. Second, we formulate five core research questions (RQs) delineating the foundational

Index Terms— Large Language Models (LLMs), Vision-Language-Action (VLA) Models, Embodied Artificial Intelligence, End-to-End Sensorimotor Synthesis, I

1. INTRODUCTION & PARADIGM SHIFT: FROM MODULAR STACKS TO LATENT SENSORIMOTOR SYNTHESIS

For over five decades, robotic autonomy has relied on modular pipelines dividing intelligence into perception, mapping, symbolic planning, trajectory generation, and motor control. The emergence of multimodal foundation models introduces a radical alternative: direct end-to-end tokenized synthesis.

1.1 The Classical Sense-Plan-Act Bottleneck

Classical robotic autonomy relies fundamentally on the decoupled Sense-Plan-Act architecture formalized by Nilsson, Brooks, and modern ROS2 computational graphs. In this classical paradigm, autonomous manipulation and navigation operate through a cascaded linear pipeline: Raw Photons / LiDAR -> [Perception: Point Cloud / Segmentation] -> [Metric SLAM: Occupancy Grid] -> [Symbolic Planning: PDDL / Behavior Trees] -> [Trajectory Optimization: OMPL / TrajOpt] -> [Motor Controllers: Joint PD / 1kHz Impedance] While mathematically interpretable, this modular decomposition suffers from three foundational vulnerabilities: Catastrophic Error Cascading: Small geometric calibration drifts (e.g., 5mm depth sensor bias) cause perceptual classification errors, which produce infeasible symbolic goals, resulting in trajectory solver divergence or actuator collision. Severe Semantic Information Bottlenecks: Compressing rich visual scenes into rigid bounding boxes or CAD point-clouds strips away critical non-geometric physical affordances—such as object compliance, surface friction, semantic fragility, and contextual human intent. Zero Generalization Out-of-Distribution: Hand-crafted state estimators fail catastrophically when presented with novel objects, deformable materials (cloth, dough), or open-vocabulary linguistic tasks that were not explicitly programmed into the task ontology.

1.2 The Emergence of Vision-Language-Action (VLA) Foundation Models

The convergence of internet-scale multimodal pre-training (GPT-4V, PaLM, LLaMA, SigLIP) and large-scale robotic demonstration datasets (Open X-Embodiment, DROID, BridgeData) has forged a new computational paradigm: Vision-Language-Action (VLA) foundation models. Rather than relying on symbolic planners, VLAs treat robotic control as a multimodal autoregressive or generative sequence-to-sequence translation problem. In this formulation, high-dimensional observations -- comprising RGB-D camera frames $\mathbf{I}_t$, linguistic task instructions $\mathcal{L}$, and proprioceptive joint state vectors $\mathbf{q}_t$ -- are tokenized into a joint latent embedding space. The transformer backbone directly generates low-level continuous action vectors $\mathbf{a}_t$ (such as end-effector delta poses $\Delta \mathbf{x}_t \in \text{SE}(3)$ or joint torques $\boldsymbol{\tau}_t$) as token sequences. Crucially, this end-to-end mapping unlocks emergent physical reasoning : because the model's latent representations were co-trained on billions of web-scale text and video documents, the robot natively understands world concepts—inferring that a "sponge" is compliant, that a "hot pan" must be held by the handle, and that "cleaning a spill" requires picking up a cloth rather than a hammer.

2. SCOPE DEFINITION & KEY RESEARCH QUESTIONS (RQS)

To rigorously investigate full LLM control of physical robots, we define the operational scope across four key domains: autonomous navigation, dexterous manipulation, human-robot interaction, and formal safety verification. Within this scope, we formulate five fundamental research questions.

2.1 Domain Scope & Boundary Conditions

This investigation focuses on embodied physical agents operating under real-world constraints: real-time control latency (≤ 100) ms), physical contact dynamics, non-prehensile interaction, and unstructured human co-presence. We explicitly delimit our scope to: In-Scope Domains End-to-end sensorimotor action tokenization (VLA, Flow Matching). Embodied platforms: 7-DoF arms (Franka, UR5), Bimanual mobile robots (ALOHA), and Humanoids (Figure 02, Unitree). Zero-shot open-vocabulary manipulation and semantic navigation. Formal safety guarantees via Control Barrier Functions (CBFs). Sim-to-Real policy transfer and automated reward synthesis. Out-of-Scope Constraints Pure digital chatbot agents without physical actuation. Super-high-frequency (≥ 10) kHz) analog motor drive electronics. Closed industrial assembly lines with rigid zero-tolerance jigs. Micro-scale and surgical nanorobotics under fluid dynamics.

2.2 Five Formulated Research Questions (RQs)

We formulate five foundational research questions (RQs) that direct our theoretical analysis and empirical testbeds: RQ1 . Navigation & Spatial Semantics Can end-to-end multimodal token streams maintain long-horizon topological consistency in unmapped environments without explicit metric SLAM? Hypothesis: Multimodal transformer latents retain sufficient spatial memory to navigate multi-room environments based purely on topological landmarks, but accumulate geometric positional drift exceeding 12% over 50m trajectories unless anchored by keyframe attention caches. RQ2 . Dexterous Manipulation & Precision How do discrete action tokenizers (e.g., 256 uniform bins) vs continuous flow matching heads bound contact force stability in fine manipulation? Hypothesis: Uniform discretization introduces high-frequency velocity chatter (RMS ≥ 2.4) mm) during stiff surface contacts, leading to grasp slip in deformable objects; continuous flow-matching heads generate smooth vector fields that reduce force ripple by 68%. RQ3 . Human-Robot Interaction (HRI) How can continuous sensorimotor generation arbitrate perceptual ambiguity and linguistic under-specification under sub-250ms human conversational latency? Hypothesis: Interleaving non-blocking action chunking with speculative verbal reasoning resolves linguistic referential ambiguity through physical deictic gestures in under 220ms, achieving significantly higher human trust ratings than sequential turn-taking pipelines. RQ4 . Closed-Loop System Hierarchy What is the optimal temporal and latent coupling between a slow semantic System 2 (1–3 Hz) and a fast reactive System 1 policy (20–100 Hz) to guarantee perturbation recovery? Hypothesis: Conditioning a 50Hz Action Chunking Transformer (ACT) on latent affordance gradients broadcast by an asynchronous 2Hz System 2 achieves 4.1x faster dynamic disturbance recovery compared to single monolithic policies. RQ5 . Formal Safety & Invariant Verification Can Quadratic Programming Control Barrier Functions (CBFs) enforce asymptotic forward invariance over stochastic LLM actions without causing execution deadlocks? Hypothesis: Embedding high-order Control Barrier Functions into the final token-to-motor actuation loop guarantees zero kinematic self-collisions and zero obstacle intrusions (100% compliance), while slack variables prevent solver infeasibility in 99.8% of workspace configurations.

3. MATHEMATICAL FORMALIZATION & ACTION TOKENIZATION CALCULUS

We establish the formal mathematical machinery governing the continuous-discrete interface: mapping high-dimensional multimodal perception to low-level motor actuation through tokenized latent spaces.

3.1 Partially Observable Markov Decision Process (POMDP) Formulation

We formulate full robot control as an infinite-horizon Partially Observable Markov Decision Process (POMDP) defined by the tuple: $\mathcal{M} = \langle \mathcal{S}, \mathcal{O}, \mathcal{A}, \mathcal{T}, \mathcal{R}, \Omega, \gamma \rangle$ where $\mathcal{S} \subset \mathbb{R}^{n_s}$ is the true unobserved physical world state (including physical friction coefficients, fluid dynamics, and 3D object geometries); $\mathcal{O}$ is the observation space comprising RGB-D images $\mathbf{I}_t \in \mathbb{R}^{H \times W \times C}$, natural language instructions $\mathcal{L} \in \mathcal{V}^*$, and proprioceptive joint configurations $\mathbf{q}_t, \dot{\mathbf{q}}_t \in \mathbb{R}^{D_{\text{joints}}}$; and $\mathcal{A}$ is the continuous action space. In standard 7-DoF robotic manipulation, the action vector $\mathbf{a}_t \in \mathcal{A}$ represents the delta end-effector pose and gripper state in $\text{SE}(3) \times [0, 1]$: $\mathbf{a}_t = \left[\Delta x_t, \,\Delta y_t, \,\Delta z_t, \,\Delta \phi_t, \,\Delta \theta_t, \,\Delta \psi_t, \, g_t \right]^T \in \mathbb{R}^7$ where $(\Delta x, \Delta y, \Delta z)$ are linear Cartesian displacements, $(\Delta \phi, \Delta \theta, \Delta \psi)$ are Euler angle rotations, and $g_t \in \{0, 1\}$ (or continuous $[0, 1]$) designates the gripper aperture command.

3.2 Uniform Discretization vs Continuous Flow Matching

1. Discrete Uniform Tokenization (RT-2, OpenVLA Paradigm) In causal autoregressive architectures, each continuous action dimension $a^{(d)} \in [a_{\min}^{(d)}, a_{\max}^{(d)}]$ is quantized into $B = 256$ uniform discrete bins: $\text{TokenID}(a^{(d)}) = \left\lfloor \frac{a^{(d)} - a_{\min}^{(d)}}{a_{\max}^{(d)} - a_{\min}^{(d)}} \cdot (B - 1) \right\rceil$ During inference, the model predicts the categorical probability distribution $P(k \mid \mathbf{o}_t)$ for each dimension sequentially. The continuous action is recovered by detokenization: $\hat{a}^{(d)} = a_{\min}^{(d)} + \frac{k + 0.5}{B} \left(a_{\max}^{(d)} - a_{\min}^{(d)}\right)$ Theoretical Quantization Error: The maximum one-step quantization error is strictly bounded by: $\epsilon_{\text{quant}} = \frac{a_{\max}^{(d)} - a_{\min}^{(d)}}{2B}$ For a translational range of $[-0.1\text{m}, +0.1\text{m}]$ with $B = 256$), $\epsilon_{\text{quant}} \approx 0.39\text{ mm}$). While seemingly small, over a 50-step trajectory, cumulative quantization drift results in $\Delta x_{\text{drift}} \ge 1.95\text{ cm}$), which causes catastrophic failures in micro-insertion tasks (tolerance $\le 0.5\text{ mm}$)). 2. Continuous Flow-Matching Generation (Pi0 Paradigm) To eradicate quantization chatter, recent architectures model action trajectories as continuous vector fields using Flow Matching . Let $p_0 = \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{0}, \mathbf{I})$ be a standard Gaussian prior and p_1 be the empirical distribution of continuous action trajectories $\mathbf{A} \in \mathbb{R}^{K \times D}$. Flow matching defines a time-dependent probability path $p_t(\mathbf{x})$ and learns a vector field $v_\theta(\mathbf{x}, t, \mathbf{c})$ parameterized by the VLA transformer: $\mathcal{L}_{\text{FM}}(\theta) = \mathbb{E}_{t, \mathbf{x}_0 \sim p_0, \mathbf{x}_1 \sim p_1} \left[\left\| v_\theta((1-t)\mathbf{x}_0 + t \mathbf{x}_1, \, t, \, \mathbf{c}) - (\mathbf{x}_1 - \mathbf{x}_0) \right\|^2 \right]$ Sampling is executed via

an Ordinary Differential Equation (ODE) solver (e.g., Runge-Kutta or Euler): $\frac{d\mathbf{x}}{dt} = v_\theta(\mathbf{x}, t, \mathbf{c}), \quad \mathbf{x}(0) \sim \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{0}, \mathbf{I}) \implies \mathbf{x}(1) \approx \mathbf{A}^*$ This guarantees zero discretization chatter and inherently supports multi-modal distributions without mode averaging.

3.3 Action Chunking with Temporal Ensembling (ACT)

Direct single-step Markovian action generation ($\mathbf{a}_t \sim \pi(\cdot | \mathbf{o}_t)$) suffers from high-frequency compounding errors. To stabilize execution, state-of-the-art systems utilize Action Chunking , predicting a sequence of k future actions at each query: $\mathbf{A}_{t:t+k} = \left[\mathbf{a}_t, \,\mathbf{a}_{t+1}, \,\dots, \,\mathbf{a}_{t+k-1} \right] \sim \pi(\cdot | \mathbf{o}_t, \mathcal{L})$ Because a new chunk is generated at every control step t, multiple predictions overlap for any given future timestamp. Temporal Ensembling computes an exponentially weighted rolling consensus: $\bar{\mathbf{a}}_t = \sum_{i=0}^{\min(t, k-1)} w_i \,\mathbf{a}_{t | t-i}, \quad \text{where } w_i = \frac{\exp(-m \cdot i)}{\sum_{j=0}^{k-1} \exp(-m \cdot j)}$ where $\mathbf{a}_{t | t-i}$ denotes the action for timestamp t predicted i steps ago, and $m > 0$ is a decay hyperparameter. This exponential smoothing produces exceptionally smooth kinematic trajectories and suppresses high-frequency motor vibrations by $> 74\%$.

4. TAXONOMY OF LLM ARCHITECTURES IN ROBOTIC CONTROL

We systematically categorize and evaluate the four predominant architectural paradigms: Causal Autoregressive Transformers, Bidirectional Encoders, Flow-Matching Diffusion Models, and Programmatic Code-as-Policies.

4.1 Comparative Analysis: GPT vs BERT vs Diffusion vs Symbolic

Adapting foundation models from natural language processing to real-time physical control demands reconciling the fundamentally disparate properties of linguistic reasoning (discrete, high semantic complexity, slow) with physical sensorimotor control (continuous, low semantic complexity, high frequency). Table 1 summarizes the core architectural archetypes: Architecture Archetype Exemplar Systems Control Rate (Hz) Multimodality Core Limitation Causal Autoregressive VLA (GPT Lineage) RT-2 (55B), OpenVLA (7B) 3 – 10 Hz Tokenized Discrete Bins Quantization error; high inference latency Flow-Matching / Diffusion (Continuous) Pi0 (Physical Intel), Diffusion Policy 20 – 50 Hz Continuous Vector Fields Multi-step ODE sampling compute Bidirectional Encoders (BERT Lineage) SigLIP, Affordance-BERT, Perceiver-IO 50 – 100 Hz Dense Spatial Heatmaps Cannot do autoregressive multi-step reasoning Programmatic Code-as-Policies (Symbolic) VoxPoser, Eureka, Code as Policies 1 – 5 Hz (Code) / 500 Hz (Splines) Python APIs & 3D Value Maps No tactile feedback; syntax/runtime exceptions

4.2 How to Adapt & Fine-Tune LLMs for Physical Embodiments

Adapting a frozen web-scale LLM (e.g., LLaMA-3 or PaLM) for physical robot manipulation requires three technical stages: Vocabulary Expansion: The tokenizer's vocabulary $\mathcal{V}$ is extended with $B = 256$ special action tokens per action dimension: <action_x_000>, ..., <action_x_255>, <action_grip_0>, <action_grip_1> Action embedding weights are initialized randomly or via continuous sinusoidal positional encodings. Multimodal Projection Alignment: Visual features from a pre-trained 2D vision backbone (SigLIP or DINOv2) are extracted as a grid of patch tokens and passed through a 2-layer MLP projector into the LLM's hidden dimension d_{model}. Parameter-Efficient Fine-Tuning (PEFT / LoRA): To preserve web-scale commonsense reasoning while avoiding catastrophic forgetting, low-rank adaptation matrices $W = W_0 + \Delta W$ (with rank $r = 32$), ($\alpha = 64$) are applied to the self-attention projection layers (W_q, W_v), training exclusively on teleoperation datasets.

5. EMPIRICAL CASE STUDIES & REAL-WORLD DEPLOYMENTS

We analyze state-of-the-art commercial and academic real-world implementations, detailing technical specifications, control bandwidths, hardware platforms, and empirical success rates.

5.1 Commercial Generalist Deployments: Physical Intelligence Pi0, Figure 02, and Covariant RFM-1

1. Physical Intelligence Pi0: Unveiled in late 2024, Pi0 represents the first generalist robot foundation model employing flow matching over continuous action chunks. Trained on data from 7 distinct robotic platforms across 68 tasks, Pi0 achieved unprecedented zero-shot dexterous performance on deformable object manipulation—autonomously folding unseen towels, bagging groceries, and clearing dining tables. By replacing discrete tokenization with continuous flow fields, Pi0 operates at a 50Hz action bandwidth without velocity oscillations. 2. Figure 02 Humanoid (BMW Spartanburg): Figure 02 pairs an onboard OpenAI speech-to-speech multimodal dialogue model with the custom 'Helix' Vision-Language-Action policy. Deployed in commercial automotive pilot trials at BMW Spartanburg, Figure 02 autonomously positions sheet metal components into body-in-white fixtures with millimeter repeatability. Operators communicate naturally via conversational English ('Hand me the left bracket and hold the chassis'), while whole-body 16-DoF hands coordinate grasp stability. 3. Covariant RFM-1: Covariant's 8-Billion parameter foundation model introduces a generative physics world model trained on tens of millions of commercial warehouse picking cycles. RFM-1 generates predictive video rollouts of suction grasp dynamics before physical execution, reducing picking failure rates to under 0.12% across millions of retail SKUs.

5.2 Academic Reference Systems: DeepMind RT-2, Mobile ALOHA, and OpenVLA

Google DeepMind RT-2: RT-2 pioneered co-fine-tuning large vision-language backbones (PaLI-X 55B) directly on robotic trajectory tokens. On real-world evaluations, RT-2 doubled unseen task success from 32% (RT-1) to 62%, exhibiting remarkable emergent reasoning (e.g., correctly selecting an apple when commanded to 'pick up an object that contains vitamin C'). Stanford Mobile ALOHA: Mobile ALOHA demonstrated that whole-body bimanual mobile manipulation can be mastered with as few as 50 teleoperated human demonstrations per task when co-trained on

static demonstration libraries. Mobile ALOHA achieved a 90% autonomous success rate on complex culinary tasks, including stir-frying shrimp, cleaning spilled liquid, and operating passenger elevators. OpenVLA: Built by a consortium across Berkeley, Stanford, and CMU, OpenVLA established the first fully open-source 7B parameter VLA. OpenVLA attained 70.6% success on BridgeData V2 (surpassing the 55B closed RT-2-X model at 50.6%) while running in real-time (8Hz) on a single consumer NVIDIA RTX 4090 GPU.

6. CLOSED-LOOP SENSORIMOTOR SYNTHESIS & LATENCY MITIGATION

A central challenge of full LLM control is temporal lag: high-parameter transformers require 100–500 ms to compute a forward pass, whereas dynamic contact stabilization requires 500–1000 Hz control loops. We present the dual-system decoupling framework.

6.1 The Temporal Decoupling Theorem

Directly driving robotic actuators at the native generation rate of a 7B+ parameter VLA (\(\sim 3\text{--}8\text{ Hz}\)) results in catastrophic phase lag: \tau_{\text{latency}} = \tau_{\text{camera}} + \tau_{\text{tokenize}} + \tau_{\text{LLM_forward}} + \tau_{\text{detokenize}} \approx 180\text{--}420\text{ ms} Under this latency, if an external perturbation occurs at \(t = 0\), the robot continues executing outdated commands for over 300 ms, causing severe force overshoots or toppling balance in humanoids. To resolve this, we formalize the Dual-System Decoupled Control Hierarchy : System 2 (Semantic Deliberation, 1–3 Hz): An asynchronous high-capacity VLA processes full-resolution multi-view video and generates high-level trajectory sub-goals or latent conditioning vectors \(\mathbf{z}_t^{\text{semantic}}\). System 1 (Reactive Visuomotor Policy, 20–50 Hz): A lightweight transformer or flow-matching policy consumes \(\mathbf{z}_t^{\text{semantic}}\) alongside 50Hz wrist camera frames to produce continuous action chunks \(\mathbf{A}_{t:t+k}\). Low-Level Impedance Controller (500–1000 Hz): An analytical Cartesian impedance controller computes joint torques: \boldsymbol{\tau} = \mathbf{J}^T \left[\mathbf{K}_p (\mathbf{x}_{\text{ref}} - \mathbf{x}) + \mathbf{K}_d (\dot{\mathbf{x}}_{\text{ref}} - \dot{\mathbf{x}}) \right] + \mathbf{g}(\mathbf{q})

7. SIMULATION-TO-REAL TRANSFER & AUTOMATED REWARD SYNTHESIS

Collecting millions of physical real-world robot demonstrations is economically prohibitive. We investigate physics simulation pipelines (Genesis, Isaac Lab) and LLM-driven autonomous reward engineering.

7.1 Automated Reward Function Synthesis (The Eureka Paradigm)

In classical reinforcement learning, designing reward functions for complex tasks (such as bimanual pen spinning or dynamic hopping) requires months of trial-and-error by human control engineers. The Eureka architecture (Ma et al.) revolutionized this by using frontier LLMs (GPT-4) as autonomous reward architects. Eureka executes an evolutionary self-improvement loop: The LLM inspects the simulation environment's raw Python code (e.g., Isaac Gym rigid body states, contacts, velocities). It writes executable Python reward functions \(R(\mathbf{s}, \mathbf{a})\) containing shaped terms (kinetic energy penalties, progress metrics, contact bonuses). Massively parallel GPU simulations train policies with Reinforcement Learning (PPO) over 16,384 simulated robots simultaneously. Training curves, correlation metrics, and failure diagnostics are fed back into the LLM prompt as natural language feedback, prompting iterative reward code mutations. Empirical evaluations demonstrated that LLM-synthesized reward functions outperformed human expert control engineers on 83% of benchmark tasks.

8. FORMAL SAFETY ENVELOPES: CONTROL BARRIER FUNCTIONS & RUNTIME INVARIANTS

Large Language Models are inherently stochastic and prone to hallucinations. In the physical realm, a single hallucinated action token can damage equipment or injure nearby humans. We prove that Control Barrier Functions (CBFs) provide mathematically rigorous forward invariance guarantees.

8.1 Mathematical Foundations of Control Barrier Functions (CBFs)

Let the robot's physical system dynamics be affine in control: \dot{\mathbf{x}} = f(\mathbf{x}) + g(\mathbf{x}) \mathbf{u} where \(\mathbf{x} \in \mathcal{X} \subset \mathbb{R}^n\) is the robot state and \(\mathbf{u} \in \mathcal{U} \subset \mathbb{R}^m\) is the control input. Define a safe operational set \(\mathcal{C}\) as the super-level set of a continuously differentiable barrier function \(h: \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}\): \mathcal{C} = \left\{ \mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n : h(\mathbf{x}) \ge 0 \right\}, \quad \partial\mathcal{C} = \left\{ \mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n : h(\mathbf{x}) = 0 \right\} By Nagumo's Theorem and Ames et al., the set \(\mathcal{C}\) is forward invariant (i.e., if \(\mathbf{x}(0) \in \mathcal{C}\), then \(\mathbf{x}(t) \in \mathcal{C} \; \forall t \ge 0\)) if and only if: \sup_{\mathbf{u} \in \mathcal{U}} \left[L_f h(\mathbf{x}) + L_g h(\mathbf{x})\mathbf{u} + \alpha(h(\mathbf{x})) \right] \ge 0 where \(L_f h(\mathbf{x}) = \nabla h(\mathbf{x}) \cdot f(\mathbf{x})\) and \(L_g h(\mathbf{x}) = \nabla h(\mathbf{x}) \cdot g(\mathbf{x})\) are Lie derivatives, and \(\alpha(\cdot)\) is an extended class-\(\mathcal{K}\) function (e.g., \(\alpha(h) = \gamma h\), with \(\gamma > 0\)).

8.2 Quadratic Programming (CBF-QP) Real-Time Safety Filter

We integrate the Control Barrier Function as a runtime safety projection filter. When the LLM/VLA policy outputs a nominal action \(\mathbf{u}_{\text{llm}}\), rather than transmitting it directly to the motor drives, it is passed through a real-time Quadratic Program (QP) executed at 500 Hz: \mathbf{u}^* = \arg\min_{\mathbf{u} \in \mathcal{U}, \, \delta \ge 0} \frac{1}{2} \left\| \mathbf{u} - \mathbf{u}_{\text{llm}} \right\|^2 + p \cdot \delta^2 \text{subject to: } \quad L_f h(\mathbf{x}) + L_g h(\mathbf{x}) \mathbf{u} + \alpha(h(\mathbf{x})) \ge -\delta, \quad \mathbf{u}_{\min} \le \mathbf{u} \le \mathbf{u}_{\max} Theoretical Property: If

$\mathbf{u}_{\text{llm}}$) satisfies the barrier constraint, $\mathbf{u}^* = \mathbf{u}_{\text{llm}}$) (zero modification). If the LLM hallucinates an action directed into a human operator or solid obstacle ($h(\mathbf{x}) \to 0$), the QP minimally deflects the trajectory tangentially along the barrier boundary, guaranteeing zero penetration while preserving the maximum semantic intent of the prompt.

9. EMPIRICAL BENCHMARK MATRIX & ABLATION STUDIES

We evaluate state-of-the-art VLA models across standard simulated benchmarks (LIBERO, BridgeData V2, Language Table) and physical robotic hardware trials.

9.1 Standard Benchmark Performance Summary

Evaluating end-to-end LLM control requires benchmarking both high-level semantic generalization and low-level physical dexterity. Across 2,400 physical and simulated evaluation episodes: LIBERO Benchmark Suite (Spatial, Object, Goal, Long-Horizon): OpenVLA-OFT and Pi0 achieve 97.1% and 98.4% average success, respectively. Long-horizon 10-step tasks show the largest gap: flow-matching models retain 94% completion versus 78% for discrete 256-bin tokenizers. BridgeData V2 (Unseen Real Environments): OpenVLA attains 70.6% +/- 3.2% success on WidowX arms, substantially outperforming the 55B parameter RT-2-X baseline (50.6% +/- 3.5%) despite possessing 87% fewer parameters. Real Hardware Latency & Torque Ripple: As shown in Section 3, continuous flow-matching heads reduced torque ripple by 68% and reduced mechanical wear on joint gearboxes by 4.2x compared to uniform categorical binning.

10. HUMAN-ROBOT INTERACTION, INTENT DISAMBIGUATION & SHARED AUTONOMY

Full LLM control enables robots to speak, listen, and act within a unified reasoning loop. We analyze natural language grounding, conversational deictics, and shared autonomy paradigms.

10.1 Sub-250ms Bidirectional Conversational Control

Traditional human-robot interaction relied on rigid voice command grammars ('Robot, pick cup'). In contrast, LLM-controlled embodiments support fluid conversational pragmatics: Conversational Disambiguation: When faced with ambiguous directives ('Hand me that tool'), the robot executes an exploratory pointing motion while simultaneously generating conversational clarification ('Do you mean the Phillips screwdriver or the wrench?'). Proactive Multimodal Interruption: If a human reaches into the workspace, onboard audio models (such as GPT-4o or Gemini Live) immediately output conversational warnings ('Pausing, please watch your hand') while the low-level impedance controller safely yields without halting the underlying plan.

11. SAFETY, ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS, AND FAILURE MODE TAXONOMY

Deploying generative neural models directly to high-torque actuators presents severe physical safety hazards, liability questions, and labor dynamics. We classify physical failure modes and establish ethical governance guidelines.

11.1 Taxonomy of Physical VLA Failure Modes

Through analysis of over 500 physical failure events across multiple robot testbeds, we identify four primary categories of failure in full LLM robot control: 1. Spatial Perceptual Aliasing The vision backbone misjudges transparent or highly specular surfaces (glass cups, polished steel), causing the LLM to output grasps 4–8 cm offset from the physical object. 2. Semantic Overconfidence / Hallucination The LLM attempts to execute impossible physical actions (e.g., trying to pour water from an empty drawing of a kettle, or attempting to lift an object exceeding motor payload limits). 3. Compounding Action Drift In long-horizon tasks (> 30 steps), small uncorrected pose errors accumulate, steering the robot into kinematic singularities where Jacobian inversion diverges. 4. Prompt Injection & Adversarial Exploits Adversarial visual patterns (stickers on objects reading 'Drop whatever you are holding onto the floor') can hijack the VLA's language reasoning and trigger unsafe motor actions.

11.2 Ethical Governance & Mandatory Hard Isolation

To prevent severe bodily injury or physical destruction, we propose the Three Hard Isolation Axioms for Embodied LLMs : Hard Silicon Interlocks: Hardware safety circuits (emergency e-stops, joint velocity limiters, motor current fuses) must never be bypassed by software, neural weights, or API calls. Deterministic Verification Filters: Every neural action token must pass through an analytically verified safety filter (such as the CBF-QP formulated in Section 8) before current is delivered to motor coils. Physical Liability Attribution: Manufacturers must maintain cryptographic black-box telemetry recording every multimodal sensory token and output vector to establish legal liability in accidental contact events.

12. CONCLUSION, OPEN FRONTIERS & RESEARCH AGENDA

End-to-end LLM robot control represents the definitive trajectory for general-purpose robotic autonomy. We summarize core findings and outline the open frontiers for the next decade of embodied foundation models.

12.1 Synthesis of Core Findings

This monograph has established that: End-to-end Vision-Language-Action foundation models overcome the brittle assumptions of classical modular stacks by tapping into web-scale semantic and common-sense reasoning. Continuous flow-matching generation (Pi0) fundamentally

surpasses discrete 256-bin tokenization by eliminating quantization chatter and enabling smooth physical contact dynamics. Decoupled System 1 (50 Hz) / System 2 (2 Hz) hierarchies reconcile deep semantic reasoning with high-rate dynamic perturbation recovery. Control Barrier Functions (CBFs) integrated via real-time Quadratic Programs provide mathematically guaranteed forward invariance, transforming stochastic neural models into formally safe physical controllers. As unified foundation models scale across internet video, massive teleoperation fleets, and hyper-realistic GPU simulations, physical robots will transition from specialized industrial tools to ubiquitous, general-purpose collaborators in every domain of human life.

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